



BETTERIDE

Go-To-Market Activation

A Data-Driven Guerrilla Marketing Case Study

Noe Elamine

Berlin, Germany

Note: Betteride has not officially launched yet, so I cannot report on final outcomes. However, in just two weeks of B2B outreach, 15 bike shops in Berlin have already joined the platform. B2C activation is planned for late February 2025. The strategy and tactics described below represent the go-to-market framework I developed and am currently executing.

THE CHALLENGE

Betteride is a two-sided marketplace connecting cyclists with local bike repair shops in Berlin. I was brought on as the sole marketing resource to develop and execute the full go-to-market strategy.

The constraints were significant.

Limited marketing budget to get started

Faced the classic cold start problem where we needed bike shops AND users at the same time, but neither would join without the other

Local bike shops were wary of platforms, having seen marketplaces extract value without bringing in real customers

Handled everything alone, from strategy to execution to creation

MARKET CONTEXT

Berlin's Cycling Landscape

Berlin is one of Europe's most cycle-friendly cities, which made it an ideal launch market but also meant we needed to stand out in an already active ecosystem.

The scale of opportunity

Berlin has approximately 710 bicycles per 1,000 residents, with around 500,000 people cycling daily. Cycling accounts for 13–17% of all trips in the city. Across Germany, there are now 89 million bicycles and e-bikes on the roads, with the bicycle market valued at €6.33 billion in 2024.

The repair opportunity

What made this particularly interesting for Betteride was the repair segment. Almost 90% of bicycle businesses reported significant increases in workshop turnover in 2024, according to the VSF (German bicycle retail association). Germans are notably attentive about maintaining their bikes, with regular repairs and maintenance being common practice. At the same time, the average bicycle now costs over €1,600, making professional repairs more worthwhile than ever.

The problem we could solve

Berlin also faces a significant problem with bike theft and abandonment. In 2023, an average of 78 bikes were stolen each day, with only 4.6% of cases ever solved. This results in thousands of damaged, neglected, and abandoned bikes across the city, precisely the kind of bikes whose owners might need a convenient repair solution.

Sources: Berlin Police, ZIV (German Bicycle Industry Association), VSF, Statista, ADFC

STRATEGIC INSIGHT

Why Charlottenburg

Rather than spreading thin across all of Berlin, I used demographic data to identify the optimal beachhead district for launch. Charlottenburg-Wilmersdorf emerged as the clear choice.

The demographic case

Charlottenburg is consistently described as one of the wealthiest neighbourhoods not only in Berlin but across Germany. Academic research and real estate analysis confirm that it has relatively high income levels and a low unemployment rate. The area is known for its quality-conscious residents, luxury shopping, and cultural institutions.

Recent migration data shows that high-income newcomers to Berlin increasingly gravitate toward Charlottenburg, particularly international professionals. The district has approximately 336,000 residents, providing sufficient scale for initial traction.

Why this mattered for Betteride

- Higher disposable income means a greater willingness to pay for convenience rather than attempting DIY repairs
- Quality-conscious residents are more likely to value professional service and trust established local businesses
- The area has strong existing cycling infrastructure and culture, so we were tapping into established behaviour rather than trying to create new habits

The beachhead logic

By concentrating all resources in one affluent, cycling-friendly district, I could create a visible presence and word-of-mouth density. When the same person sees a Betteride flyer at their cafe, a door hanger on their bike, and hears a neighbour mention it, that repetition builds recognition and trust far faster than scattered citywide exposure ever could.

Sources: Berlin socio-demographic studies, Guthmann Real Estate Research, academic research (Brandt 2011), Berlin Statistics Office

THE GTM STRATEGY

Dual-Track Approach

I developed two parallel strategies that reinforced each other, one for cyclists (B2C) and one for bike shops (B2B).

For cyclists (B2C)

I focused on guerrilla physical activations. These were low-cost, high-visibility tactics designed to build awareness and curiosity.

For bike shops (B2B)

I focused on trust-first relationship building. This meant face-to-face outreach, a risk-free onboarding model, and positioning Betteride as a partner rather than another extractive platform.

Why physical activation made sense

With a near-zero budget, traditional digital channels were simply not viable. Customer acquisition costs for marketplace apps can range from € 15 to € 50+ per user through paid social or search. Betteride could not compete there.

But guerrilla marketing offered a different path. Research consistently shows that businesses using guerrilla tactics spend up to 90% less on advertising than traditional methods while achieving strong memorability. A 2023 Nielsen study found that 75% of consumers remember brands that use unique advertising approaches.

Physical activation also created a meta-benefit for B2B sales. When bike shop owners see Betteride flyers and activations appearing in their neighbourhood, it signals commitment and legitimacy before I even step through their door.

The distinctive visual identity reinforces this approach. Betteride's purple and yellow colour scheme was chosen deliberately to stand out in the urban environment. Most cycling brands default to predictable palettes like black, red, or corporate blue. Purple and yellow create immediate visual differentiation, making flyers, door hangers, and street activations impossible to miss. When someone sees that colour combination multiple times across Charlottenburg, brand recognition develops rapidly without any paid media spend. The bold branding also signals confidence and professionalism to bike shop owners, reinforcing the legitimacy that physical presence already establishes.

Sources: Love Creative Marketing, Nielsen/Alt Terrain 2023, Journal of Economics

B2C ACTIVATION

The Guerrilla Arsenal

I developed five distinct activation tactics, each designed to be memorable, low-cost, and directly relevant to the target audience.

1. The "Dead Bicycles Museum"

This is a guerrilla street installation concept that will "curate" abandoned and broken bicycles as mock museum exhibits. Each bike will receive a humorous plaque describing its condition: "Flat Tyre Fred, abandoned 2019, dreams of riding again" — with Betteride branding and a QR code inviting owners to "bring them back to life."

The concept is designed to tap into a real, visible urban problem that Berlin residents recognise and relate to. It should be unusual enough to photograph and share, creating organic social spread. And it will cost essentially nothing, using found and abandoned materials.



2. Door Hangers

I have designed door hangers to be placed directly on bikes, showing visible damage, flat tyres, rusty chains, and broken lights. This will be hyper-targeted by definition. Only people who actually need the service will receive the message, delivered at the exact moment they encounter their neglected bike.



3. "Fake Parking Tickets"

These are humorous citation-style notices designed to look like parking tickets at first glance. The "violation" listed is neglecting your bicycle, with the message: "Repair your bike, do not use your car." The format taps into Berlin's strong sustainability culture while being memorable enough that people will keep them rather than immediately discarding them. Production is extremely cheap. I acquired a refurbished bill printer, making the cost per unit negligible.



BETTERIDE.EU
Mobilitäts-Notiz

Fix dein Rad, lass dein
Auto.



**BETTERIDE.EU | Weil kaputte
Räder niemand weiterbringen.**



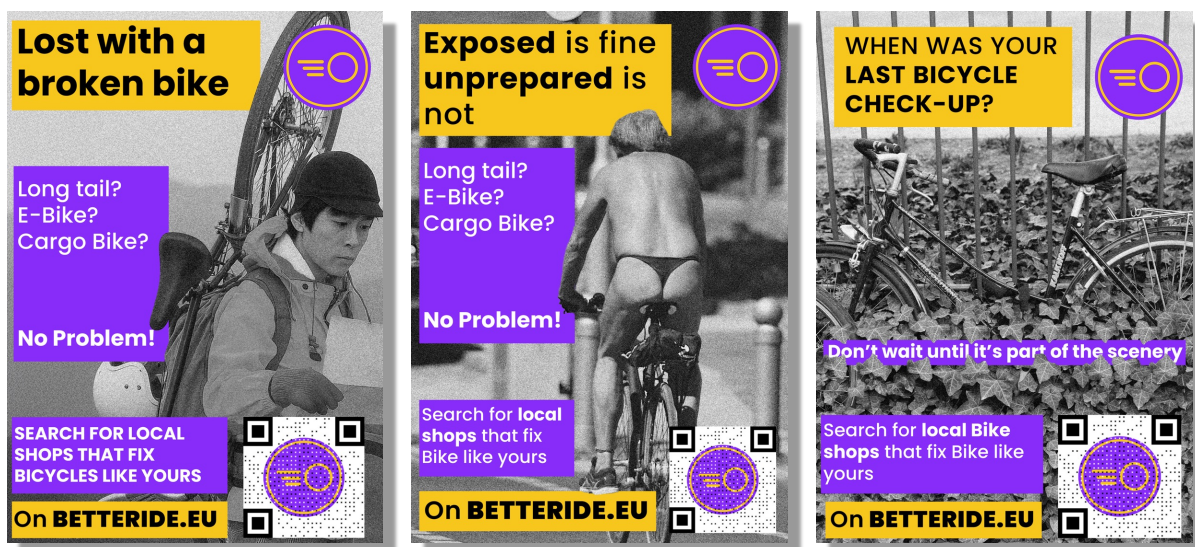
Dies ist kein offizieller Strafzettel.

4. Three Flyer Variants

I have created three distinct flyer designs to test different messaging approaches:

These will be distributed at cafes, co-working spaces, and U-Bahn stations throughout Charlottenburg.

The flyers are currently in English. This is a deliberate choice based on the demographic data: migration research shows that high-income newcomers to Berlin increasingly gravitate toward Charlottenburg, particularly international professionals. By starting in English, we target this affluent, internationally mobile segment who are more likely to value convenience and professional service and who may face additional friction finding German-language repair options. German-language variants will follow as we expand.



Total estimated cost for all B2C materials: under €700

B2B STRATEGY

Building Trust with Bike Shops

The B2B side required a completely different approach. Local bike shops have legitimate reasons to be skeptical of platforms many have seen marketplaces promise customers but deliver only fees and administrative burden.

My approach centred on eliminating risk entirely.

Face-to-face first

We visited every target shop in person. No hard sell, no pitch deck. Just introduction, listening, and understanding their specific pain points around seasonality, visibility, and competition from larger chains.

Risk elimination through the freemium model

Shops could join the platform completely free, with no commitment and no time limit on the free period. They only began paying after two specific conditions were met.

The conversion trigger

Once a shop received their first customer through Betteride, proving the platform actually delivered value a two-month countdown began. After those two months of demonstrated ROI, a commission on platform-sourced bookings would apply.

This model flipped the traditional dynamic entirely. Instead of asking shops to pay for the promise of customers, I let them experience real value first. The risk sat entirely with Betteride, not with the partner.

Why this will work

B2B marketplace research consistently emphasises that these platforms are significantly more trust-sensitive than traditional e-commerce. As one analysis put it, "to truly replace processes founded on individual relationships, a marketplace has to make a strategic commitment to trust-building activities from day one."

This approach is already showing results. In just two weeks of outreach, 15 bike shops in Berlin have joined the platform before any B2C activation has even begun. By letting shops experience value before any payment conversation, I am converting skeptics into partners. A shop owner who receives customers through the platform will not be a sales target they will be a satisfied advocate.

Sources: Sharetribe Marketplace Research, US Chamber of Commerce B2B Guidelines, B2B Marketplace Analysis

WHY THIS APPROACH MAKES SENSE

The constraints I face have actually shaped a stronger strategy than a larger budget might have produced.

Physical activation builds credibility that digital cannot.

In a market full of apps and platforms, tangible presence in the neighbourhood signals genuine commitment. Bike shop owners can see we are investing in their area, not just sending cold emails from somewhere else.

Concentrated geography creates density.

By focusing exclusively on Charlottenburg, every activation will reinforce the others. A cyclist might see the museum installation, then notice a door hanger on their own bike, then spot a flyer at their regular cafe. That repetition builds recognition far faster than scattered citywide exposure.

The freemium B2B model aligns incentives.

Shops have nothing to lose by joining, which removes the primary objection. And once they experience real customer flow, the conversion conversation becomes collaborative rather than adversarial.

Solo execution forces prioritisation.

I cannot do everything, so I focus ruthlessly on the highest-impact tactics. Every hour goes toward activities that directly drive either user awareness or shop partnerships.

KEY LEARNINGS

Constraints breed creativity.

Having no budget forced unconventional thinking that actually differentiated Betteride from better-funded competitors.

Trust cannot be shortcut.

B2B relationships require face time, demonstrated value, and patience. Emails and decks are not enough.

Data informs but does not decide.

The Charlottenburg demographic data pointed the way, but on-the-ground observation refined exactly where and how to activate.

Physical and digital reinforce each other.

Physical activations drove digital engagement (QR scans, app downloads), while LinkedIn content warmed up B2B prospects before in-person visits.

Guerrilla marketing works when it is authentic.

The "Dead Bicycles Museum" concept should succeed because it addresses a real problem Berlin residents recognise. It is not just clever — it is relevant.

ABOUT THIS WORK

I am developing and executing this entire GTM strategy independently as the sole marketing resource for Betteride.

This includes:

- Market research and district selection
- Brand positioning and messaging strategy
- All creative asset development (flyers, door hangers, fake tickets, museum concept)
- B2B sales strategy
- LinkedIn content creation

B2C activation is planned for late February 2025. I am happy to discuss the strategy in more detail and share the physical assets.

Noe Elamine

MSc Strategic Marketing, Imperial College Business School

noe.elmne@gmail.com